

“We did not want total dependence on children. In the US, they have busy lives. We had no friends our age.”

AFTER 10 YEARS OF TOING AND FROING between India and the US, Daljit Singh and Swarn Mongia settled down in an old-age home in Delhi. They certainly don't lack friends now.



SUMET INDER SINGH

front to the world—is more of a Bollywood reality now. Urban sprawl and spiralling cost of living do not allow three generations to live together. And modernity is kicking in. “There’s a new premium on privacy, personal choice and less tolerance for cramped communal living,” he adds.

Add to it, the pull of migration. With young people moving out in search of better prospects, caring for the old has become an elusive ideal. Mumbai and Kolkata are witnessing a rapid migration, says the just-published UNEPA report, *State of the World Population*. One-third of the population in India—350 million—no longer lives in their place of birth, says the Census, and 7 per cent of elderly couples live on their own. Kerala has the largest population of seniors and the highest number of migrants. The *Need Assessment Study*, 2002, of the elderly by the Department of Economics and Statistics shows 50,000 households in Kerala have 60-plus people living alone; over 10 per

cent have children working abroad and 21.7 per cent households are headed by aged people.

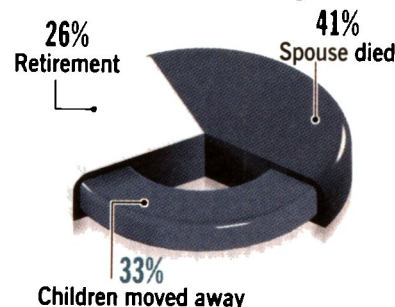
Solitude is Sujata Menon's main companion these days. The 69-year-old lives in Anna Nagar, Chennai, all by herself in a flat that her son, a doctor in the UK, bought for her. She went there recently on a six-month visa but returned after barely six weeks, unable to bear the weather. Her daughters live in her city but she gets to see them just once or twice a month—they are busy with their own lives. She feels lonely and scared: “All sorts of people try to come in and find out if I live alone.” She is yet another face among 4.9 million women who, according to the Census, live all by themselves; yet another lonely-heart out of the national total of 11 per cent; yet another solitary soul among the 33 per cent who live without their spouses. “Living arrangement is an important component of the welfare of the elderly,” says Rajan. “The most vulnerable are elderly women in urban areas.”

But seniors are fighting back too. To beat the insecurity of old age, they are

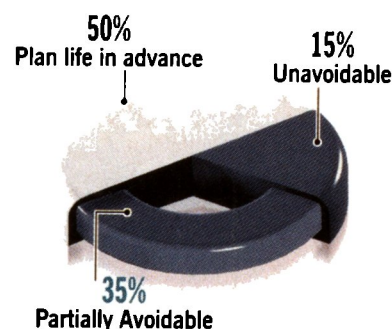
FACING THE BIG EMPTY

What does it mean to grow old? Seniors talk about loneliness...

Why do you feel lonely?

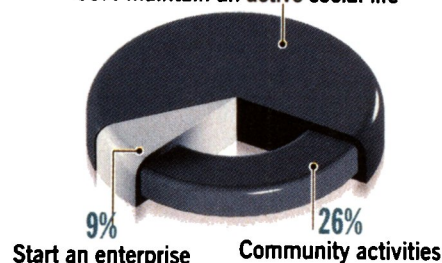


Can you avoid loneliness?



How do you deal with loneliness?

65% Maintain an active social life



Source: HelpAge survey, 2004, on 500 seniors, age 70-85, in Delhi and Mumbai

71%

men own assets, lack self-reliance.

70%

of the elderly are supported by their children.